of seven Nobel Prize winners of Indian origin, three have been Tamil Brahmins, all of them scientists.

These two Indias may form a political whole, but in cultural terms they are chalk and cheese, old and new, volcanic and alluvial, *shakti* and *shiva*, rice and wheat, *todi* (think toddy) and soma (the mysterious intoxicant drunk by the early Arya), *dosa* (rice pancake) and chapatti (unleavened flatbread), water buffalo and cow, Dravida and Arya. This North–South difference is neatly epitomised in the current leaders of these two states. In UP the newly installed Chief Minister at the time of writing is a Hindu nationalist belonging to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) – the lean, shaven-headed, saffron-clad Rajput firebrand Yogi Adityanath, the *mahant* (head) of the Goraknath *math* (monastic order) at Gorakhpur. In TN it is the stocky, moustachioed figure of Edappadi Palaniswami, drawn from the dominant Gounder or Kongu Vellalar agriculturalist and landowning community, and a stalwart of the All-India Anna Dravida Munnetra Party, which until her recent death was dominated for years by the matriarch Jayalalithaa, known to her devotees as Amma (mother) or *Thanga tharagai*, the 'golden girl'.

But perhaps the greatest difference of all is in language. The further you travel south of the Narmada River the stronger that sense of Dravidian or Tamil identity becomes – and the louder that liquid, bubbling, melodic sound of spoken Tamil and its variants.

This division between North and South is at its most obvious when the major language groups spoken on the Indian subcontinent are plotted on a map (see Map 1). Today almost 94 per cent of first languages spoken in India belong to one or other of the two dominant language families: Indo-Aryan, spoken by about 74 per cent of Indians, and Dravidian, spoken by about 24 per cent. So three-quarters of India's present-day population speak one or other of the Sanskrit-based Indo-Aryan languages such as